ANARCHOTICS



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Introduction

Last summer, I started preparing for writing this essay. I knew then that it could be helpful for me to just try to gather my thoughts a bit. I started to write short sentences in my notebook whenever I got a thought in my head that seemed relevant to what I do creatively. I tried to be open and write down exactly what I was thinking. I was planning to use these notes as a part of this text. In the end, I only ended up using one of them, but writing them was an important start.

I want to approach this text intuitively and try to write in a free format.

In my life and in my artistic pursuit, I am very interested in and inspired by history and archaeology. I read a lot on these subjects, but I also get information through other channels, such as social media. In this text I will write about a few historical objects and events. I will however not approach these from the perspective of a historian or an archaeologist, since I am neither, rather I will write about them from my own subjective, emotional, artistic point of view.

I want to write about how I try to look at symbols and how I try to pick them apart, both in my thinking as well as in my creative processes.

Anarchy

The word anarchy means, among other things, to me, to look at and contemplate power structures and how they work. David Graeber was a thinker and writer working in an anarchist tradition. He has been an important source of inspiration to me the last year or so. Lately, I have been reading a collection of his essays called *The Ultimate Hidden Truth*. The title is part of a longer quote: "The ultimate hidden truth of the world is that it is something that we make, and could just as easily make differently"[1]. This is a thought that resonates deeply in how I look at the world, but also in how I approach creative thinking. In a 2006 interview[2] he talks about *direct action* and what that term can mean in an anarchist context. In short, he gives the example that if a community is out of drinking water, in more normative political movements you would ask a politician to dig a well. Direct action would mean to instead dig the well yourself and "dare them to stop you"[3]. He goes on to say that "in a way,

[1] R. Solnit. Foreword. In: D. Graeber. *The Ultimate Hidden Truth of the World*, Penguin Books, 2025, ix
[2] Youtube, A Conversation With Anarchist David Graeber (2010), https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=PVDkkOAOtV0 (Accessed 2026-04-01)
[3] Ibid

anarchism is about acting as if you are already free". I think this is a very interesting and attractive thought, acting as if you are already free. This is very similar to how I try to think when I am in my own creative world. I find being and moving in normal society to be an unbelievably claustrophobic experience, and therefore I want my creative world to be different, to feel open. I do not approach writing this text through the lens of anarchism, rather, one of my approaches is through how I think about anarchism and what those thoughts say about me and how I try to position myself in the world. I think that anarchism is an idea or a practice, and not necessarily an identity.

Material/thought

I want to write about definitions. When I think they can be important and helpful, and when I think they might make the world seem more firm than I think that it really is.
Last summer, I wrote this in my notebook:
"We are nature – nature is not something else – it's not an other. We are in nature right now. We are also in space right now"
I do not agree with this really. I think it is unnecessarily harsh or uncomplicated in a way that I do not like. What I think now is that the word nature is a human form or shape, that puts us outside, or perhaps rather on top of everything else. On one side there are us humans, that are intelligent, smart, civilized, and are somehow just more refined than *everything else*. On the other side is *everything else*. I would argue that this is a mistake or a misunderstanding. It also feels related to our idea about intelligence and what intelligence makes us. For humans, intelligence and having advanced language has been crucial for our survival. If you are a pigeon or bacteria, this would however be completely unnecessary, for them other capacities are more important. Like flying.
I do not think that our intelligence makes us more important, or that our existence is somehow *more* than that of other species. But this very pompous view of us humans as being better than everyone else seems to be a very central part of our society. At the same time, I feel that there are only certain types of intelligence that are valued. Often, they seem to be related to language, specifically written language.
I think that what I am trying to put into words here are my thoughts on material reality versus collective agreements or fantasies. There is a thing made out of flesh and blood, a bunch of atoms, that is your body. Then there is the character or mythology that is your person. There

is of course nothing wrong with this, this is how humans work, but sometimes I think it can be important to rethink or reevaluate these fantasies, especially the ones that are being forced upon us, and forced upon some more than others. Like states, and money. I will try to give an example.

There is the made up, mythological idea of a thing called Sweden. In Sweden there are laws. If you do not follow these laws, the state will use its capacity for violence, performed by the judicial system to punish you. If you do not work or otherwise are a productive part of the capitalist machine, the capitalist system will punish you. You will not have money which will force you into homelessness and poverty. This brings up the question: does the state and the capital have your best interest in mind?

You are not obligated to live by anyone else's fantasies, especially not ones that are literally engineered to hurt you.

This way of thinking also applies to other aspects of life, even in your personal life. Homo sapiens have lived on earth for approximately 300,000 years.[4] Before that, other types of humans have been around even longer. One thing I take away from thinking about that time perspective is that human cultures have probably looked quite different in different times. One of the things that ties us together is however creativity. When I write that, I mean creativity in a broad sense of the word. I mean that a plumber, a nurse or – even if it hurts to say – a politician can be creative in what they do, as much as a person that makes a stone axe.

This time perspective also means that art academies have been around for a relatively short period of time. That certainly does not make them less valid or irrelevant. It also does not make them more valid or relevant. What I am trying to say here is that the human tradition of making things has a relatively long history, which means that you can also make up your own rules, or lack thereof, of how you make things. I think that almost everyone can be creative, but almost no one is allowed to be so. If you starve or even if you just work a full-time job, it is very difficult to live creatively. If you work all the time or if your life is mostly about surviving, you do not have time to express yourself. This will probably cause a lot of emotional dissonance since being creative is a central part of being human. This is however an easy hole to slip in to, also when having the privilege of being allowed to live a creative life. I find it very easy to be stressed all the time, to have too many projects going on at the same time, to constantly be on the edge of burn out. Probably a lot of people reading this can relate to that feeling. In a way, it is almost as if you are *supposed* to feel like that. Then the

[4] Wikipedia, Human evolution (2026-03-16), https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Human_evolution (Accessed 2026-04-01)

question is, why? One of the reasons that I want to live a creative life is so that I can feel that I have a firm distance to society. However, when I am stressed about deadlines all the time, I feel like I am part of society, part of the industry. I find that one of the things that I value the most in my life is having time to think. To either sit down, or to be out walking and not doing anything else than just thinking. I love that. I want to have more of that in my life. But when I am busy all the time, I have less of that.

The freedom of meaninglessness

The words nihilism and meaninglessness have for a long time had a really positive ring to me. I have not read Nietzsche or really any theory surrounding nihilism, so the positive feeling I get out of these words are more in relation to my own interpretations, the feelings I have about them. They have a similar meaning as the word anarchism has to me. It is about abandoning other people's arbitrary set of rules for how you should or should not live your life. It opens my horizon of thinking, and more importantly, it asks the question; what is on the other side of giving up these rules? If there is no external, objective set of rules, this would mean that we are free. Free to do what we want on earth. This would include being kind to each other and tolerant of our differences.
This is one of the things that I try to explore in my creative work: freedom. The cultural understanding of *freedom* here in the west has in many ways been conquered by capitalism and the political right. What I mean is that it is easy to connect the image of a bald-headed eagle or an American flag waving in the wind with the word *freedom*. But one could also make the argument that all nations are by nature oppressive and constructed with the intent of being so.

History and archaeology

History and archaeology are important sources of inspiration to me. The idea of different living creatures having lived on this planet before I or we did is interesting. Before that, no one lived here. Before that, there was not a here. In a while, no one will live here. All of this opens up my perspective on life on this planet and my role in the universe. I also like the thought of digging in to the ground to look through remnants of what other people have left behind. In my creative work I use almost exclusively found objects. When looking for and

picking up things I feel a bit like some kind of urban, do-it-yourself archaeologist. I do not know how to write this following sentence without sounding pretentious, nostalgic or overly sure of my own ideas, but I will give it a go. One part of me thinks that the only way that homo sapiens can live on earth without ending up *absolutely miserable* or creating awful situations for each other is to live in some kind of hunter gatherer lifestyle. I think that a lot went wrong when we started farming, roughly 12,000 years ago. [5] When we started farming, we had to start plan ahead in a new way. For example, we needed to keep seeds for growing next year. Farming also meant that we started living in one spot. This meant that we could start having more things, more objects. I think that the fantasy of owning started at this time. In essence, walking around the streets of Stockholm, preferably at night, picking up stuff that I find makes me feel more like a human. Some kind of archaeologist/hunter/gatherer. That is my little fantasy, and that fantasy makes me more content with being alive.

Petroglyphs

For as long as I can remember, I have been interested in petroglyphs and rock art. Growing up in Stockholm, the kind of petroglyphs that I have had most access to would be runestones. What I have found most intriguing has always been that you can go look at these things, and you can put your hand exactly where another person had their hand, thousands of years ago.

Outside Sollefteå in northern Sweden, there is a place called Nämforsen. In that area there is an exceptionally high concentration of petroglyphs.[6] Many of the images depict elk. When I have read about Nämforsen, it is often thought to have been a place of worship. This makes sense in some ways, and elk was an incredibly important animal to the people that lived there, just in terms of being a source of food, of fur, of bone. A very important animal for survival, which in extension could have meant that the people living there thought of them as sacred. I would think that his is true. However, I remember reading a post about this in an archaeology related Facebook group. A person wrote in the comment section comparing the petroglyphs to the tv show Den stora älgvandringen (The Great Elk Migration). Every spring for thousands of years, herds of elk cross Ångermanälven. They do so in order to reach their summer pastures. In Den stora älgvandringen you get to see this, when the elk cross the water. The

[5] Wikipedia, History of Agriculture (2026-03-31, https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/History_of_agriculture, (Accessed 2026-03-31)
[6] Wikipedia, Nämforsen (2026-01-30), https://sv.wikipedia.org/wiki/N%C3%A4mforsen

show is filmed in a place called Kullberg, which is close to Nämforsen. I will try to explain what it is that I am thinking about: now in current times we have this tv-show which shows elk when they are on their yearly migration. I do not know what it means that this show is on, but I guess it is rooted in some kind of curiosity. And perhaps there is a similar reason behind the petroglyphs. It is sometimes easy to think that people in earlier societies lived in a world of complete magical explanation. Where everything was religiously explained. But of course, these people were no less complicated than we are.
I think a lot about why all of this exists. The universe, me, elk, other people, other planets. Probably most people think a lot about that. Maybe some of the people that carved elk on the rocks at Nämforsen thousands of years ago were thinking about that. At least, it makes my life feel less lonely, thinking that they did.
Whether the art was made out of existential need and curiosity or as part of a religious system we will never know. I am guessing probably both.
Worth noting is that there is roughly 2300 years between the oldest and the newest carved elk.



A couple of years ago, I read a text about a certain type of stone axes that was used in the bronze age. I can not remember where I read this, but I will try to explain how I remember the text. When bronze as a material was introduced in Scandinavia, it was at first very expensive. The only people who could afford to buy bronze tools were people with a lot of resources, typically a king or a chieftain. When you make for example axes, you usually have a cast made out of two parts. The two parts are put together and you pour in warm, liquid bronze.

You then take the cast apart and there you have your axe. On the axe you will see a seam where the two parts of the cast meet.



People that could not afford bronze axes would still be using ones made of stone. In archaeological finds from this time period, stone axes have been found that looks like the one in the image above. On the top of the axe you can see what is supposed to imitate a casting seam. The stone axe is made to look fancier than it really is. This gives an interesting insight in the life of the person who used this axe, a couple of thousand years ago.
I think that this is one of the most important things that learning about history and archaeology does for me, it makes my life seem less isolated. I understand that there have been people living on earth for hundreds of thousands of years. People that have had fun, that have been angry, sad, that have felt grief, jealousy and joy. Even though how we live now in our society and on earth is so obviously wrong, there might not be a right way. This is it, no one knows why we are here or why we exist. This is what all of us have in common.
The same goes for art making, it makes my life feel less lonely. Both that being creative and making stuff is a company in and of itself, but also that it opens for possibilities to be with other humans, on a deep level.

Death metal

In my opinion, one of the most interesting cultural phenomenon to come out of the place we sometimes refer to as Sweden would be death metal. Without going too far into this subject, in the 1980s there were a few different new genres of music invented. The umbrella term for them would be *extreme metal*. These could be divided into thrash metal, death metal, black metal and so on. They were certainly international phenomenon happening across the world, but what Sweden, and Stockholm in particular got most famous for was its own brand of death metal. When I in my teenage years in the early 2000s found my way to this type of music, that was a really inspiring thing. What was probably even more inspiring was that most of the people that invented this type of music were teenagers when they did. I got to know that the people that had invented the music that I loved had done so at youth centers in Farsta, Bredäng, Skärholmen, Älvsjö, Södermalm and Upplands Väsby. And they had done it when they were my age, and generally without any proper education in music.
Underground culture was and is my biggest source of inspiration. To me, it is about creating meaning together with others. It is about a very direct contact between the people that makes and the ones that receive. Something that feels real. Community.

Approach and intent

Last November I went to see the band Swans when they came to play in Stockholm. Swans is a kind of experimental rock band from New York. Their songs often expand up to 40 minutes and seeing them perform live is a really unique experience. The music is really loud, feels at least partly improvised and has something very trance like about it, but within the framework of rock music. Swans music is a very strange mix of feeling both very magical, almost shamanistic in some ways, as well as being harshly nihilistic. The songs are very repetitive, long and have an often very strange groove. Yet, in the live performance, there is very little drama going on. The scene is strongly lit and between the songs there might be an extra sound check or someone tuning their guitar. This has been a big inspiration to me the last couple of months, and especially in relationship to my recent degree show. It inspires me to think this: “some things in our existence are incredibly clear how they work, they can not be understood in any other way, this is how it is. Almost everything else is completely impossible to

understand.” On some level, this way of thinking of course is not true. But maybe on other levels, it might be? But it does reflect a *feeling* I have about the world. Clear reality, completely incomprehensible.

Making something that is sacred can at times demand very little, other than a will to do something that is sacred.

A really important artist in my life is Genesis P-Orridge. On the title page of this essay, there is a photo of Genesis. They had many different artistic outputs in their life, but I think what has inspired me most is not the music or the art works but rather how they lived their life. There is a feeling of *total devotion* to what they did, which I really appreciate. There is a short movie about Genesis called Write your own code.[7]
In this movie Genesis says “We declare war against all binary systems”.[8] This is a sentence that has given me a lot to think about. Not only because it is positioning itself against binary ways of thinking, but because it kind of collapses on itself. I would think that a war is a binary system.

The final part
I feel incredible gratitude for having the possibility to live a creative life. The most important part or process in my life is my life. What I mean by that, is that in the overall process that is my life, everything is equal. Making things in my studio, cooking, sleeping, being with others, being alone, loving, thinking, caring, going on walks in the middle of the night, welding, laughing, working at my job, feeling like shit, painting, listening to music. They are all different parts of my life, as is everything else. Being creative, ah fuck, let’s even say that I am an artist, being an *artist* is something I experience as very light. It feels normal, intuitive, easy, organic, fun, meaningful. I have been making things in one form or another for as long as I can remember, and I can not imagine that that will ever change, but if it does, that is fine too. I want to live an open ended existence. I want to live a life that feels genuine and honest,

[7] Youtube, Genesis P-Orridge: Write Your Own Code (Trailer) (2021-12-29), https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=X1Z3sqDJLks (Accessed 2026-04-01)
[8] Ibid

and I want what I make to be that to. We are in a lot of pain, and I want to acknowledge that.

Being creative in the way that I am now has saved my life. When I found this way of expressing myself it showed me a way out of a very destructive lifestyle. And that I get to share my creative pursuits with other people, even that other people outside of my studio care about what I do is something I am very thankful for. It is something that I will never take for granted.

I am not afraid of dying, in fact, I look forward to it, in the same way that I know that at some point this day will end and I will get to rest. I am however certainly in no rush of getting there. I am very happy and grateful to be alive. I love being alive, shitty as it often is.

When writing this, I look outside my kitchen window. I see houses, trees, clouds, the sun and whatever is the backdrop behind it. There is not an answer to anything. That is ok.

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